

A QUALITATIVE METHOD IN SIX PHASES

Reflexive Thematic Analysis

How researchers turn messy qualitative data into patterns of shared meaning —
and why the researcher is part of the instrument.

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What we will cover

Three parts, one continuous argument.

01 Positioning

What TA is, the three families of TA, and what makes one of them *reflexive*.

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02 Process

The six recursive phases, and a worked example from data extract to finished theme.

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03 Practice

The design decisions you must justify, and what counts as quality.

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Sources: Braun & Clarke (2006, 2019, 2020); Byrne (2022)



PART I

Positioning the method

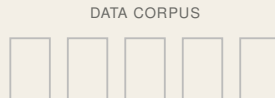
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What thematic analysis is, the three families it splits into, and why Braun and Clarke renamed theirs "*reflexive*".

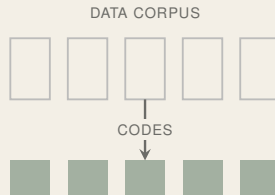
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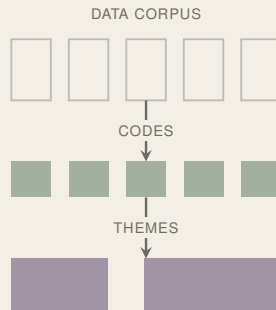
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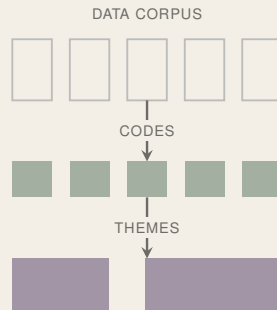
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- That paper became one of the most cited methods papers of the last twenty years.
- And then the problem started: thousands of studies *cited* it while *doing* something else entirely.



but *how* you get there
is the whole argument

Three families of thematic analysis

Same name, different philosophies. Braun, Clarke, Terry & Hayfield (2019) cluster them on a spectrum.

small q · positivist

Big Q · fully qualitative

Coding reliability

Fixed codebook, several coders, inter-rater reliability. Themes decided *before* coding.

Boyatzis (1998)

Codebook

Structured template, but qualitative values. Pragmatic, team-based, deadline-driven.

Framework; template analysis

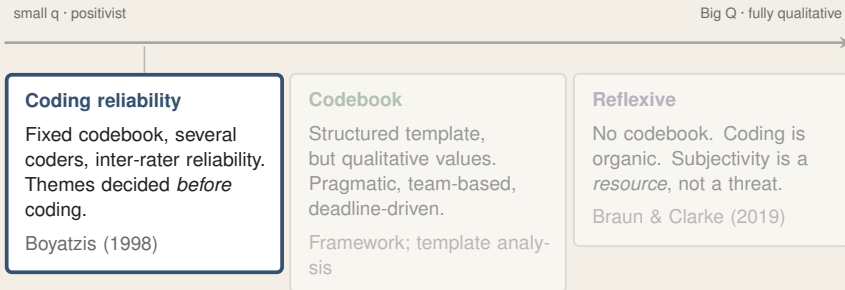
Reflexive

No codebook. Coding is organic. Subjectivity is a *resource*, not a threat.

Braun & Clarke (2019)

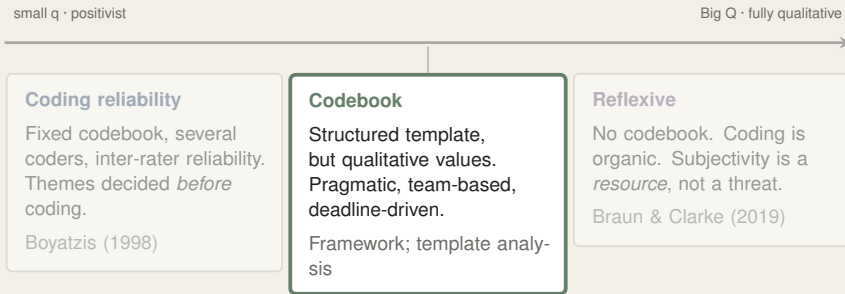
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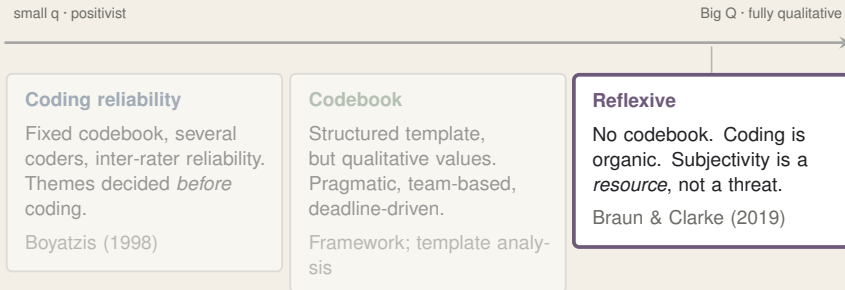
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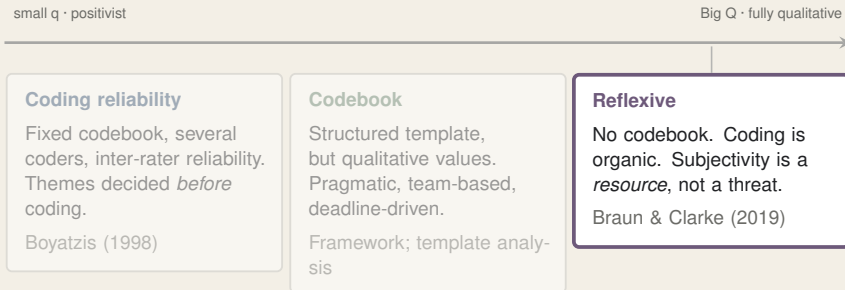
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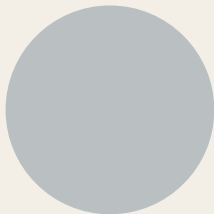
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The mistake is not choosing one. The mistake is **blending them without noticing** — citing reflexive TA and then reporting a Cohen's Kappa.

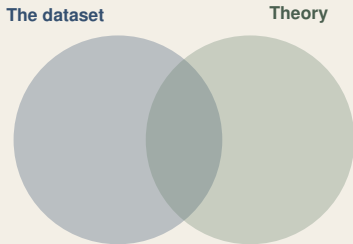
Why “reflexive”? The researcher is in the analysis

The dataset



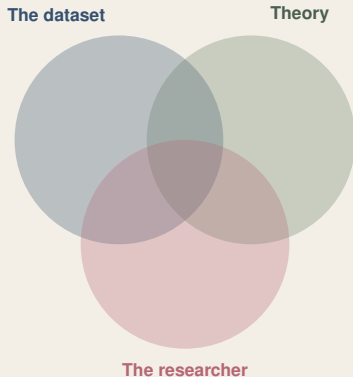
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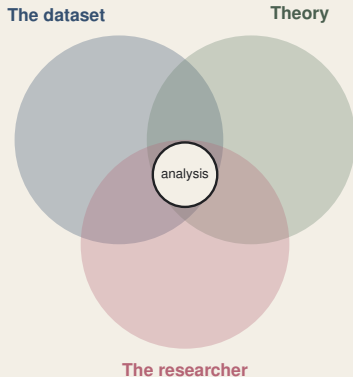
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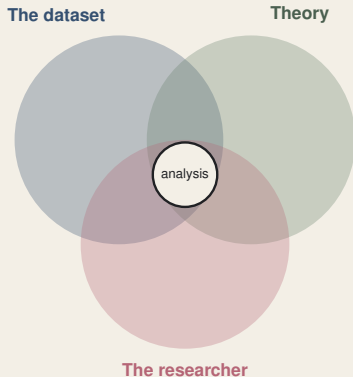
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- No two researchers meet that intersection identically — so **reproducibility is not the goal**.

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$$\mathcal{A} = f(\mathcal{D} \cap \mathcal{T} \cap \mathcal{R})$$

Change $\mathcal{R}$ and the analysis legitimately changes.

Themes are an output, never an input

“*themes do not passively emerge*”

— Braun & Clarke (2019)

The passive story

Themes lie in the data. The researcher finds and retrieves them.

The reflexive story

Themes are generated — built by the researcher out of codes.

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Braun & Clarke even renamed phase three — from *searching for* themes to *generating* themes — to kill the metaphor.